

Introduction to this *Effective practice guide*

This effective practice guide will help you understand the nature of initial and diagnostic assessment and invite you to think about the practice of assessing learners.

The guide will cover:

1. The purpose of initial and diagnostic assessment
2. Providing feedback to learners
3. Tools, methods and approaches
4. Gathering and using data

What is initial and diagnostic assessment?

Initial and diagnostic assessment begin the process of getting to know a learner and building a relationship with them.

- **Initial assessment** happens at the time of a learner's transition into a new learning programme. It is a holistic process, during which you start to build up a picture of an individual's achievements, skills, interests, previous learning experiences and goals, and the learning needs associated with those goals. This information is used as a basis for negotiating a course or programme.
- **Diagnostic assessment** helps to identify specific learning strengths and needs. It determines learning targets and appropriate teaching and learning strategies to achieve them. This is important because many learners have higher-level skills in some areas than in others. Diagnostic assessment happens initially at the beginning of a learning programme and subsequently when the need arises. It is related to specific skills needed for tasks.

The two processes are closely linked: diagnostic assessment adds to the information gathered from initial assessment. Together they help you and the learner build a clear picture of the individual in order to:

- personalise learning
- develop an individual learning plan
- begin the process of assessment for learning that will continue throughout the learner's programme
- make links to progression routes and prepare for the next

steps.

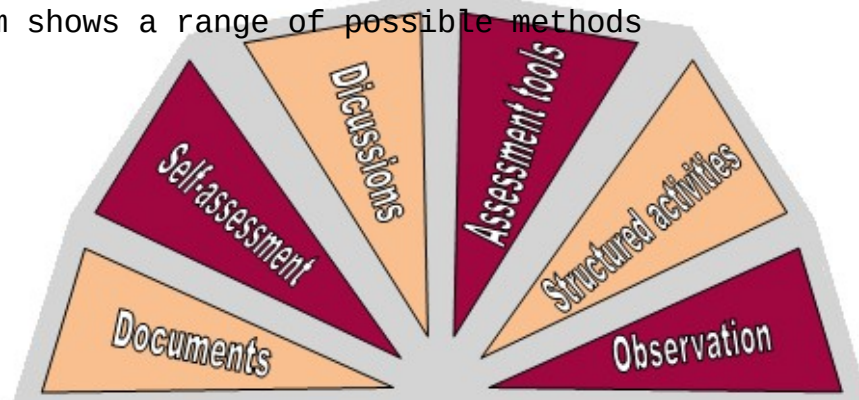
A positive experience

Initial and diagnostic assessment are among learners' first experiences of your organisation and will influence their initial impressions. If the experience is positive, active and involving, this will help to create a climate in which learners are able to negotiate and take responsibility for their learning. You can help make the experience positive for learners by:

- involving them – do the assessment 'with them' not 'to them'; supporting learners to take an active part will encourage motivation and independence
- building their self-esteem and sense of self-worth
- recognising their strengths and achievements, not just their weaknesses
- linking initial and diagnostic assessment to their own aspirations, such as their career choices or aspects of their everyday life
- making the assessment relevant to their specific context for learning.

Initial and diagnostic assessment: methods and approaches

Initial and diagnostic assessment should involve a range of methods and approaches, none of which is sufficient on its own. It is important to evaluate the quality of information obtained from particular methods. Once you have begun to get to know the learner and their learning preferences, you will be better able to select the appropriate assessment methods. The diagram shows a range of possible methods



Adapted from *The initial assessment toolkit* (Key Skills Support Programme, 2007)

- **Documents** and records give evidence of achievements and include qualifications, records of achievement, references, non-academic certificates and awards.
- **Self-assessment** gives learners an idea of where their strengths and weaknesses lie. It is vital to take learners' own views into account and to make the most of this knowledge.
- **Discussions** and interviews allow the teacher and learner to get to know each other. They also provide an excellent opportunity to feed back the results of other assessment methods and to probe more deeply.
- **Assessment tools** can play an important role in objective initial and diagnostic assessment of literacy, language and numeracy (LLN) skills. Tools are also sometimes used to assess occupational skills and learning difficulties and/or disabilities.
- **Structured group or individual activities** during induction and early parts of the programme allow learners to apply specific skills. A free writing task, for example, gives a rounded picture of how someone actually writes. Such a task also helps to put learners at the centre of the assessment process because they can write about themselves and their interests.
- **Observation** gives a broader picture of the learner and how they perform in a range of contexts. This will give insights into learners' strengths, how they work with others, how they think, how confident they are and how willing they are to ask for help.

Try this...

- Make the assessment relevant to the learner's context and interests. This may mean planning activities or using assessment tools related to a learner's vocational area or life interests.
- Gather information from activities that learners carry out in

other parts of their programme. For example, you can:

- observe them on a work placement
- use examples of their writing to assess their skills.
- Select a blend of assessment methods to suit the individual learner and their circumstances.

Who carries out initial and diagnostic assessment? What skills are needed?

Staff who carry out initial assessment are able to:

- understand the whole assessment process
- present it to learners in a positive and constructive way value and engage with learners
- use a variety of approaches appropriate to individual learners and their context for learning
- interpret results appropriately and give professional feedback to learners
- recommend learning programmes
- refer learners for further expert assessment
- use the outcomes to plan individual and group learning
- monitor progress.

It is important that staff involved in initial and diagnostic assessment are well trained and able to use professional judgement. A team approach ensures consistency and reliability and increases staff confidence and skills. If LLN tools are used as part of the assessment process, staff need to have training in their effective use.

Feedback from assessment

Giving timely, constructive feedback to individuals is crucial to effective initial and diagnostic assessment. Feedback is not a one-way process. Invite the learner to comment on what you do as well.

Try this...

- Stress the positive. Celebrate what a learner has done well. This helps to build confidence.
- Seek learners' views and value their contribution. This will help them to get better at assessing their own work, which is vital to them becoming independent learners.

- Frame questions carefully and use prompts such as 'Would you like to say more about that?'
- Pause for a few seconds after questions have been posed or responses have been given, to encourage learners to carefully consider and expand on what they have said.
- Be specific. Avoid generalisations such as 'There are a lot of inaccuracies' and instead focus on individual points which you can discuss with the learners.
- Focus on things learners can change, and avoid overloading them with too much at once.
- Look for ways forward together. Share ideas and explore solutions rather than always putting forward your own suggestions.
- Agree what you will both do as a result. This could include agreeing new targets or planning learning opportunities.

Using the data: for you and the learner

Information from the initial and diagnostic assessment process should be used to develop individual learning goals and targets and to inform appropriate teaching and learning strategies and use of resources. It should be recorded in the individual learning plan, session plans and schemes of work. Effective use of assessment data:

- makes sure that planned learning is grounded in the learners' needs and priorities
- avoids learners wasting time by going over old ground unnecessarily
- reduces the risk of learners being frustrated by tasks that are beyond them.

Data should be shared with all staff supporting the learners so that all learning can be differentiated to take account of their strengths and needs.

It is important that where learners are following vocational pathways, all staff work together to plan learning in response to the findings from initial and diagnostic assessment. This ensures that learners have opportunities to develop skills in their vocational context.

Using the data: for managers and the organisation

Good initial and diagnostic assessment make a significant contribution to the overall quality of provision by:

- ensuring that learners are on the right course or programme
- maintaining motivation
- improving learners' achievement and progression.

Your organisation should require you to record assessment results on the Management Information System (MIS). Assessment data should be collated and analysed to ensure that programmes offered are appropriate for the skills profile of learners. Key messages from the assessment data relating to particular programmes should be fed back to curriculum teams to inform the development of appropriate teaching and learning strategies so that all learners are provided with suitable opportunities to develop and progress.

Note:

We use 'teaching and learning' and 'teacher' as generic terms to include:

- teaching, training and learning;
- teachers, tutors, trainers, lecturers and instructors in the further education (FE) system.

These guides are designed to support effective practice in teaching and learning, and may be used with and by Teaching and Learning Coaches. For more information on implementing the Teaching and Learning Coach programme please see the Excellence Gateway:

[http://www.excellencegateway.org.uk/node/21613.](http://www.excellencegateway.org.uk/node/21613)

Redeveloped from earlier resources on the Excellence Gateway:

[http://tlp.excellencegateway.org.uk/tlp/pedagogy/quickstartguide/index.html.](http://tlp.excellencegateway.org.uk/tlp/pedagogy/quickstartguide/index.html)

